

# Seasonal Arthritis Guide: Managing Symptoms Through the UK Y

Each season brings different challenges for arthritis. Discover how to adapt your routine month by month for year-round comfort.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · [livingwitharthritis.org.uk](https://livingwitharthritis.org.uk)

---

## Seasonal Arthritis Guide for the UK



*Openly licensed image via Openverse*

British weather is famously unpredictable — and for people with arthritis, those changes can mean the difference between a good day and a painful one. Here is how to stay ahead of your symptoms throughout the year.

## **Spring (March–May)**

**\*\*The good:\*\*** Rising temperatures and longer days encourage outdoor activity. Vitamin D levels begin to recover after winter.

**\*\*The challenge:\*\*** Fluctuating temperatures and barometric pressure can trigger flare-ups. Hay fever medications (antihistamines) can interact with some arthritis drugs.



*Openly licensed image via Openverse*

**\*\*Tips:\*\*** - Layer clothing so you can adjust to temperature swings - Start a gentle walking programme as days lengthen — aim for 20 minutes daily - Get your vitamin D levels checked; many UK adults remain deficient even in spring - Garden in short bursts (20-minute sessions) using ergonomic tools with padded grips

## Summer (June–August)

**\*\*The good:\*\*** Warmth generally eases stiffness. This is when most people with arthritis report feeling their best.

**\*\*The challenge:\*\*** Heat and humidity can cause swelling. Dehydration worsens joint lubrication.



*Openly licensed image via Openverse*

**\*\*Tips:\*\*** - Stay hydrated — aim for 2 litres daily, more in hot weather - Exercise early morning or evening to avoid peak heat - Use cooling gel packs for swollen joints - Wear supportive sandals (Birkenstock, FitFlop) rather than flat flip-flops - Apply SPF 30+ — some arthritis

medications (methotrexate, hydroxychloroquine) increase sun sensitivity

## Autumn (September–November)

**\*\*The good:\*\*** Moderate temperatures are comfortable for most. Seasonal produce (squash, berries, leafy greens) supports an anti-inflammatory diet.

**\*\*The challenge:\*\*** Dropping temperatures and increasing dampness. Reduced daylight can affect mood.

**\*\*Tips:\*\*** - Transition to warmer layers; invest in merino wool base layers that trap heat without bulk - Boost omega-3 intake with seasonal oily fish (mackerel, sardines) - Consider a SAD lamp (10,000 lux) to maintain mood as daylight hours shrink - Get your flu jab — arthritis patients on immunosuppressants are at higher risk

## Winter (December–February)

**\*\*The good:\*\*** The festive season offers social connection, which supports mental health.

**\*\*The challenge:\*\*** Cold is the number one weather complaint among arthritis patients. Morning stiffness can last significantly longer.

**\*\*Tips:\*\*** - Use an electric blanket or heated mattress pad to warm joints before getting up - Run a warm shower for 5–10 minutes each morning to ease stiffness - Keep hands warm with thermal gloves; consider heated gloves for severe Raynaud's - Maintain exercise indoors — online yoga classes, stationary cycling, or swimming in heated pools - Eat warming, anti-inflammatory foods: turmeric golden milk, ginger soups, slow-cooked stews with plenty of vegetables

## Year-Round Essentials

- **\*\*Track your symptoms:\*\*** Apps like Cloudy with a Chance of Pain (developed by the University of Manchester) help identify your personal weather triggers
- **\*\*Consistent medication:\*\*** Don't skip doses because you feel good — consistency prevents flare-ups
- **\*\*Regular check-ups:\*\*** See your rheumatologist or GP at least annually

## Key Takeaway

Understanding how seasons affect your arthritis gives you the power to prepare, not just react. Small adjustments each quarter can make a dramatic difference to your quality of life.

---

## Q&A

**Question: What is the key thing to know about seasonal arthritis guide: managing symptoms through the uk y?**

**Short answer:** Managing arthritis symptoms year-round involves adapting to seasonal changes. In spring and autumn, layer clothing to combat fluctuating temperatures. Stay hydrated in summer, aiming for 2 litres daily, and protect sun-sensitive skin. To ease winter stiffness, use heated blankets and warm showers. Consistent medication and tracking symptoms are important year-round to pre-empt flare-ups.

**Question: When should I seek professional advice?**

**Short answer:** If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

**Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?**

**Short answer:** Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at [livingwitharthritis.org.uk](https://livingwitharthritis.org.uk).

---

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · [livingwitharthritis.org.uk](https://livingwitharthritis.org.uk)